

GCP - Certifications

1. Google Cloud Certifications (GCP)

Google Cloud exams are fixed by tier. Note that these are valid for **two years** (Professional) or **three years** (Foundational/Associate).

Pro Tip: Google offers a **50% discount** on your next certification or renewal once you pass your first exam.

2. Docker Certification

The **Docker Certified Associate (DCA)** is the industry standard for Docker. It is managed by Mirantis.

- **Price:** \$195 (or €200) per attempt.
 - **Format:** 55 questions in 90 minutes (Multiple choice & Discrete Option).
 - **Validity:** 2 Years.
 - **Best For:** Professionals with 6–12 months of daily Docker experience.
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3. Kubernetes Certifications (CNCF)

These are performance-based exams (not multiple choice) where you solve tasks in a live terminal.

- **Bundles:** You can often find a **CKA + CKAD bundle for \$825**, saving around \$65.
- **Retakes:** One free retake is included if you fail the first attempt.

- **Exam Simulator:** Purchase includes two attempts at the Killer.sh exam simulator, which is much harder than the actual exam.
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4. Recommended Learning Path & Timeline

For a professional starting from scratch, here is the most efficient path:

- 1. Month 1–2: Docker (DCA Prep)**

- Focus on docker-compose, image optimization, and networking.

- 2. Month 3–5: Kubernetes (CKAD/CKA Prep)**

- Shift to Pods, Deployments, and Services. The CKAD is usually easier for developers to start with.

- 3. Month 6–7: Google Cloud (ACE Prep)**

- Learn how GKE (Google Kubernetes Engine) automates the K8s you just learned.

- 4. Month 8+: Advanced Tracks (CKS or Professional Architect)**

- Go for CKS if you are security-focused, or Architect if you are leading teams.